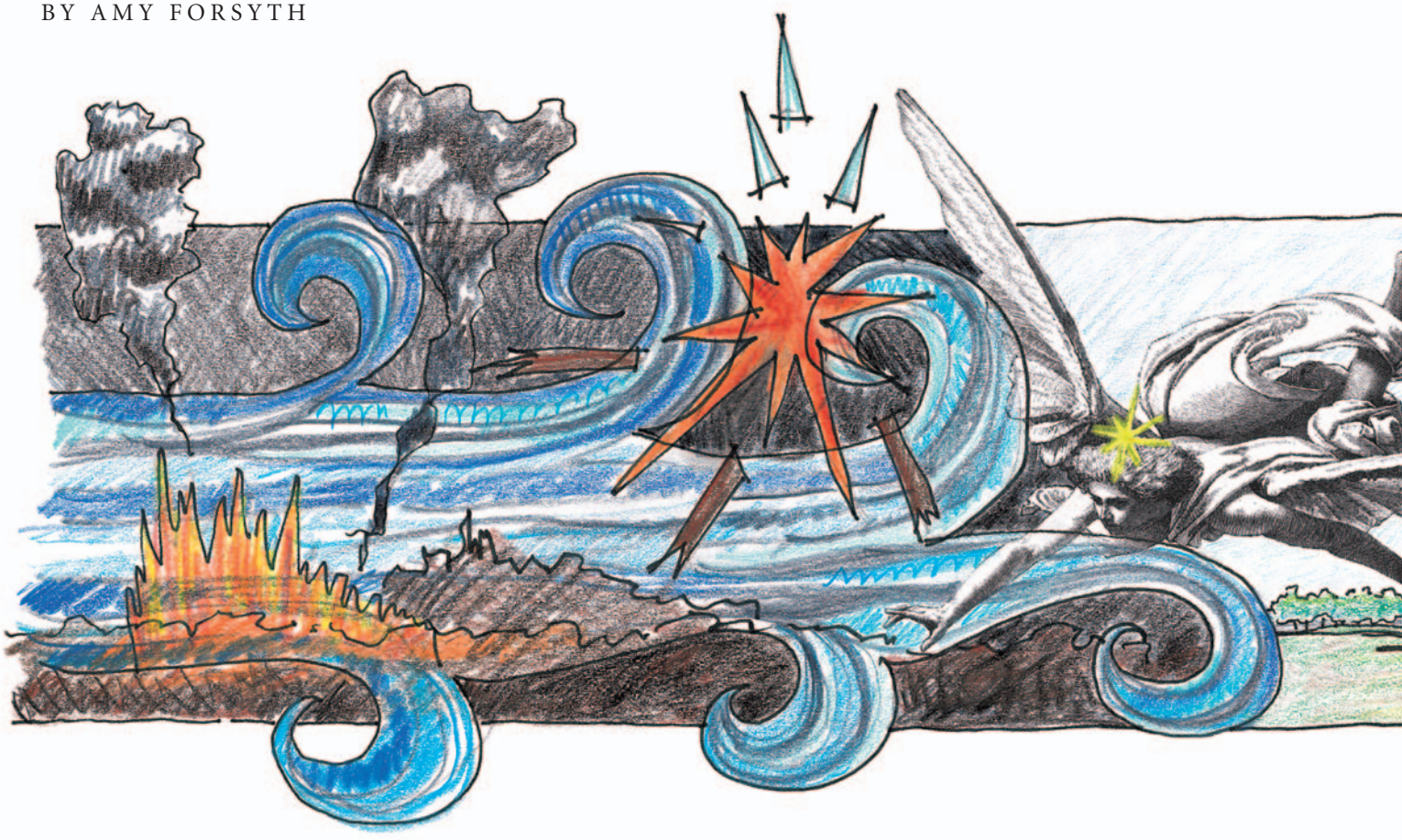
The Trouble with History
Three Case Studies

TEXT AND ILLUSTRATIONS
BY AMY FORSYTH



A Klee painting named "Angelus Novus" shows an angel looking as though he is about to move away from something he is fixedly contemplating. His eyes are staring, his mouth is open, his wings are spread. This is how one pictures the angel of history. His face is turned toward the past. Where we perceive a chain of events, he sees one single catastrophe which keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage and hurls it in front of his feet. The angel would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed. But a storm is blowing from Paradise; it has got caught in his wings with such violence that the angel can no longer close them. This storm irresistibly propels him into the future to which his back is turned, while the pile of debris before him grows skyward. This storm is what we call progress.

Walter Benjamin, "Theses on the Philosophy of History"

We can all empathize with Walter Benjamin's image of the angel of history. Every one of us has, at some point in our lives, longed desperately to reorder the past, or revisit some cherished moment that exists only in memory. This is also the root of nostalgia, which can be defined as the longing for something that never was. We become attached to the familiar objects of our past, however meager or grand, and those of us who never possessed objects of elegance wish to do so, to create a sense of belonging to some imagined culture of which we wish we had been a part. Providing a compelling and intimate environment for these dreams, furniture plays a significant part in this drama. Hence the popularity of reproduction period furniture, reflecting varying levels of quality by balancing an understanding of history with the limitations of cost. Even more rarified is handcrafted historical reproduction furniture. There are many who cherish it for its design, its construction processes, and its symbolic role in transmitting the authenticity of an earlier culture. Many makers depend upon this obscure and often misunderstood tradition for a livelihood, despite the competition with manufacturers of mass-produced furniture.

What is the relationship between the studio furniture maker and the history of furniture? What does it mean to make something new? Should we let the past remain in the past and move forward into the future? Should we build upon the past to develop a contemporary aesthetic? Can



we comfortably recreate the furniture of the past, using contemporary technology, or must we utilize the technologies of the past in order to accurately reproduce the piece? Is replication an acceptable expression of tradition, or is tradition progressive? That angel of history haunts us, but when should we emulate his backward-looking stance and when should we turn our own faces to the future?

While there may be no definitive answers to these questions, it is important for furniture makers to locate their own current beliefs within this continuum. We are not just skilled craftspeople hidden away in our shops, creating work in isolation. There is a growing awareness of studio furniture as a discipline, whatever style or era it may evoke, and we each represent a part of it in our efforts. It is the process of working, thinking, and critiquing that advances the boundaries of our discipline. When work reflects thought and reveals ideas expressive of our times, it provides a significant measure of our agenda to the larger public.

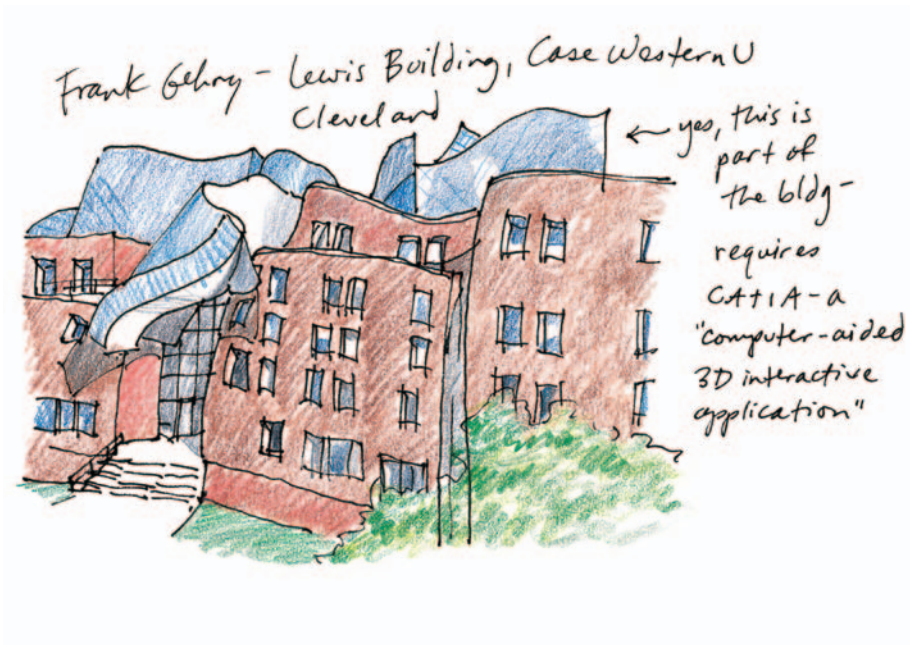
In recent years, studio furniture has been informed by the infusion of many other disciplines. There are innumerable ways in which we find our way to this field, and once here, develop our own style of work according to our own experience and outlook. As time passes, we may also find that our work shifts in its patterns with respect to its initial models.

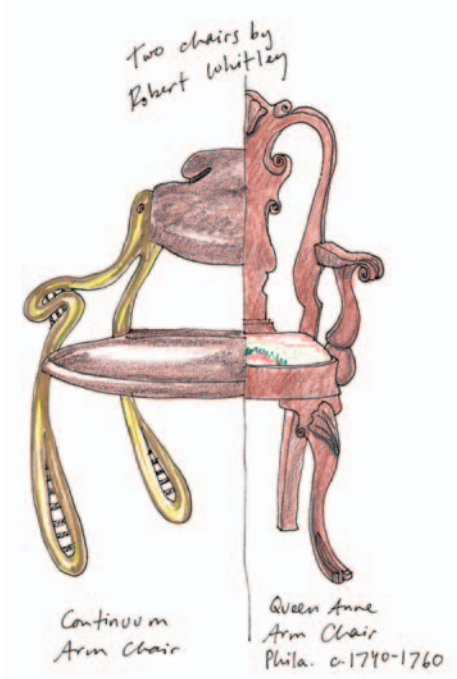
I began my design career by studying architecture in the 1980s, when the focus was on design and conceptual reinvention, and history was seen as something to assist with new ways of envisioning the future, rather than a vital entity to be preserved or recreated. The intelligent uses of materials and construction processes were not a strong point of the architecture of this period, which eventually led to various interpretations of historical motifs using an unfortunate array of synthetic materials. The era's focus on stylistic reinterpretation at the expense of quality materials soon propelled me in another direction altogether, towards the pleasures of wood and small-scale furniture construction of my own design. But until recently, the question of history was not a serious concern in my work. Perhaps as we grow older, and develop personal histories of our own, tradition becomes more compelling and more relevant than it was when we were young. We begin to see ourselves as part of a continuum, not just makers who express ideas in isolation. Rather than focusing on those things that differentiate us from the rest of the world, we start to recognize that we are part of something larger. We move from our story to history.

ISSUES OF STYLE

Style is one of the trickiest aspects of history. Arising from materials, attitudes, and processes that are popular at the time, style is the visual presence of a piece. Although each maker has a personal style, historical styles that represent an era may or may not reflect the style of a particular individual. Mysterious and changeable, a style cannot be easily recognized while it is emerging. Details appear fresh and new, and may at first seem peculiar or startling. Styles are relative to one another. We look back on an era and suddenly realize that it was known for its rounded-over cherry edges or its use of ornate carving representing plant materials. Styles have an expiration date. They are alive and popular for a certain time period, then become temporarily unfashionable, before returning, transformed, as representatives of important qualities of a past era, cleansed of its imperfections, sometimes even elevated to a position of wistful nostalgia. It is difficult to determine exactly where style comes from. Perhaps one visionary creates something that inspires a whole generation of makers. Once others begin to repeat details, over time they define a recognizable language. The initial idea may transform into something else entirely, due to reinterpretation, creative license, or even misinterpretation. The interpretive mind of Picasso transformed African mask imagery into Cubism, an entirely new conception of western art, unrelated to the cultural forces that forged the tribal art. At a more modest scale, it is enlightening to look at regional differences, such as ball-and-claw feet, to see how they contrast. But still, they are all ball-and-claw feet, rather than goat legs or wheels. How many of us understand the historical significance of claw feet? Why do we care about them now? To what extent do we accept or reject tradition, and what does it mean to be "on the cutting edge?" Can anything truly be new? Surely newness is merely a rearrangement of things we already know to create a new way of seeing. How do we set boundaries in defining the extent of departure from tradition in our designs? In the absence of tradition, is our work relevant to others? On the other hand, isn't recreating an object exactly as it was made in the past a reactionary act of historicism, rather than one of creative design? Can we transcend our era and create a piece that is "timeless"? Does that mean that it has no style, or can the essence of the piece transcend style?

When I was in architecture school, it was perfectly acceptable to emulate LeCorbusier, (who had been dead for almost thirty years), to take his ideas and build on them as my teachers had. But the work of a living architect, such as Frank Gehry, a contemporary of my





teachers, was considered an inappropriate source for imitation. Gehry had not yet defined a generally accepted stylistic language—his work merely revealed the idiosyncrasies of an individual practitioner. Ten years later, with all his successes, he is imitated everywhere—the ubiquitous computer-generated torqued and twisted forms of contemporary architecture all stem from his influence, for better or worse. Why do the critics now sanction such imitation? What does it take to shift from being a quirky individual to the progenitor of a style? Somehow, innovators speak the language of the moment, capturing the imagination of many and traveling just ahead of their time, addressing issues that others are just about to discover.

PERIOD FURNITURE IN WILLIAMSBURG: THE RECREATION OF AUTHENTICITY

In January 2002, I attended the third annual meeting of the Society for American Period Furniture Makers (SAPFM). Held in Williamsburg, Virginia, in conjunction with a workshop on period furnituremaking, co-sponsored by *Fine Woodworking*, it provided a focused and intriguing introduction to the subject of history in furnituremaking. Many of the members of the SAPFM were hobbyists, although the organizers of the group were either extremely serious amateurs (in the best sense of the word—for the love (*ama*) of the art) or professional period furnituremakers and teachers. At the banquet, the SAPFM's award of lifetime achievement, the annual Cartouche Award, was given to Robert Whitley, a reproduction furniture maker with decades of experience and an historian's eye for detail. Interestingly enough, in the slide show he presented to the members of the SAPFM, Whitley neglected to show the other side of his oeuvre-- contemporary work of his own creation. He gave me a pamphlet, which demonstrated the clear lines of demarcation between his two bodies of work. On the left-hand pages were his period furniture pieces; separately, on the right hand pages, were his own contemporary designs. How odd that someone of such accomplishment must accept this schizophrenic situation. Are the audiences for reproduction furniture and contemporary design work so different? Does it all come down to the question of psychological comfort? Some people need the familiar, while others seek the stimulation of the new. Perhaps for some, it is the old work that provides the stimulation of discovery that for others is found only in their own design of the latest trend.

As I pursued my own struggles with these questions, I was pleasantly surprised by the beauty of Colonial Williamsburg, which I had imagined, prior to my first visit, as a kind of theme park—Colonial America's equivalent of Disney World's interpretation of Europe. Although I couldn't help but think of Mickey and Minnie on seeing people in period costumes, there was remarkable historical rigor in the recreation of the village. I watched men in knickers and knee socks ripping a huge log with a pit saw. They were making a nice clean cut, but needed to stop every few minutes for a rest. The worker in the pit, peering up through the falling sawdust, got the worst end of the deal. This exhausting process is repeated for every piece of lumber used in Colonial Williamsburg, from the building siding, structures, and fences, to the immaculately precise reproduction furniture pieces, which are made today exactly as they were originally made. It is interesting to imagine the dilemma of a museum curator several hundred years hence, pondering the tool marks, the finish, the design, and wondering why they conflict with the carbon dating data (or whatever scientific process will be favored at that time). Perhaps there will be surviving records that explain that this product was an anachronism, existing at the same time as IKEA cabinets (most of which are unlikely to survive even the current decade, unless pressed fiberboard makes good fossils in a landfill) titanium hip replacements, microchips, and carbon-fiber bicycle frames. Current trends in architectural historic preservation discourage exact

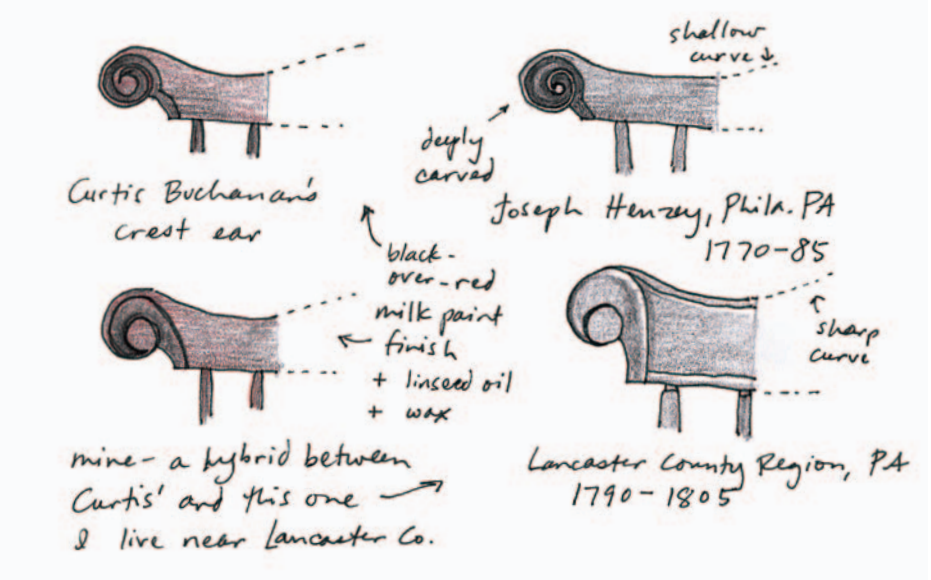
replication, and support a clear distinction between new and original elements. Does the indistinguishable recreation of historic artifacts dilute the power and clarity of the original object? Or can that angel of history manage to snag one small piece of the past and haul it into the future?

WINDSOR CHAIRS:
THE SUBTLETY OF THEMATIC VARIATION

My eyes were opened to the power of historical recreation this past summer, when I took a Windsor chair workshop from Curtis Buchanan, who makes exquisite pieces, most of which are made identically to 18th-century chairs. His designs are more elegant than most early Windsor chairs, which often exhibit ungainly proportions, especially where the legs meet the seat. Curtis' seats are deeply sculpted, giving them a lighter line while still keeping much of the mass, and the legs are more delicate than most historical examples. The students in his workshop started with one straight-grained oak log, one maple log, and some 2" slabs of pine; in a mere two (intense, sweaty) weeks, beautiful chairs emerged as exemplary models of the efficacy and delicacy of hand tools. The only power tools used were the lathe (spectacularly, with long spirals of green maple flying over our shoulders) and the bandsaw. With only minimal design opportunities, we suddenly became the next generation in a continuum of chair makers who developed their ideas and employed their tools in such a clever way that our chairs, like those of the past, will last perhaps for centuries. There was something so satisfying about being a part of this tradition, that I don't mind that I brought only a slight design modification to the comb-back that was my own. Looking at that chair, which is similar to many others, still makes me smile. Perhaps "newness" is achieved not by radical dialectical departure from the past, but by a subtle variation emerging from a solid and meaningful tradition.

WINTERTHUR:
THE REPRESENTATION OF THE PAST

In the spirit of seeking out the history of furniture and its potential in contemporary work, I visited Winterthur for the first time. Dubbed "an American Country







Estate," and possessing many acres of cultivated gardens, the museum is located in a sprawling mansion, which has been modified, with varying success, over the years. Part of the reason for its unusual exterior is that the additions were designed from the inside out. The "collector," Henry Francis duPont, one of the wealthy duPont family heirs, who lived in the house until it opened as a museum, wished to "show America as it had been." He collected pieces of woodwork from various eras —fireplaces, paneling, doorways and windows—from buildings throughout the United States, constructed rooms around them, and then assembled appropriate period furnishings to go with the woodwork. Often, an architectural molding with a particular incised curve from Maryland is echoed by the curve of a similarly detailed chair, from the same time period but a different region. Interpretation, imagination, and speculation, rather than historical precision, formed relationships between constituents in this collection. In a sense, this is the model that continues to inspire interior decorators even today. Refined personal taste in assembling historic artifacts to create a unified setting is valued over accurate historical recreation. Organized according to themes, some of the 175 period rooms at Winterthur were inhabited by the family, while others were assembled later for the purpose of exhibition to the public.

The Chinese Parlor, a showplace for some late 1700s hand-painted Chinese wall paper, was used for entertaining and filled with chinoiserie, such as Chippendale furniture with oriental influences. Exuberant Empire furniture was less popular and perhaps accumulated only to round out the collection for visitors. In some cases, the actual woodwork could not be acquired and duPont would instead have a replica built. Examples of such interpretive recreations include a beautiful curving stair that was inspired by one in North Carolina.

Winterthur is a rich resource for anyone interested in investigating period furniture, and other decorative arts, as well. In addition to programs for the public, there is an extensive library, and research fellowships and academic programs for conservationists and historians. Curators are kept busy caring for more than 85,000 historical objects, rather than creating new ones, except to demonstrate ideas related to exhibitions. We were fortunate to participate in a behind-the-scenes tour with furniture specialist and curator Michael Podmaniczky. Podmaniczky has also worked at Colonial Williamsburg, and balances his role as an historian with that of a craftsman, repairing pieces and building samples for exhibitions in addition to the more scholarly research and teaching required in such a place. His rule of thumb for historical accuracy in the building process is to imagine his power tools as apprentices. The table saw makes the cut for him that an apprentice would have in an earlier era. He then uses the appropriate hand tools and his own skills to complete the project.

CONCLUSION

Like everything else, furniture is bound by the inexorable passage of time. No matter what great leaps we make into the future, no matter how radical and shocking our current designs may appear, everything we make is destined to become someone's grandmother's furniture, tomorrow's antiques, evoking nostalgia for our romantic and distant era, barely understood and probably misinterpreted. Time will reveal our foibles to our descendants, who may ridicule or emulate us. Nevertheless, like our ancestors have done before us, we will have given future generations something worth thinking about, a history of their own to carry on.

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